



Touch sensitive space bar?

Your laptop or desktop might soon have a touch sensitive space bar called the "SmartBar", thanks to Synaptics. <http://dgit.in/touchspacebar>



Siri, please applaud me!

Next time, ask Siri to play a sound or reply with a sound effect and it would! You can even tell Siri to laugh, applaud or fart. <http://dgit.in/siriseffect>

Feature

the most expensive, costing Rs. 199 per month. More importantly though, it's the way the app works.

The Guvera Music app is designed in a way that it caches music when you play it. This means that playing a track for the second time will not need data. Essentially, Guvera is allowing you to download tracks even when you're on the free plan. See what we mean? The app is targeted at users who will stream for free, with the message being the same as it is when you're watching television – 'deal with the ads if you want to save money'.

The reason we found Guvera to be a pleasant surprise though is its collection. Not only does the app look nice on the web, Guvera's collection is really formidable, for both Indian and international music. Comparing our collection from Rdio on Guvera, we found one song by Peete Seeger that was missing on Guvera.

The deal breaker for us with Guvera was that it doesn't allow streaming over 64kbps, irrespective of the kind of connection you have.



Guvera

Wynk

Airtel's Wynk music could easily have been one of the top contenders if it wasn't designed primarily for the telecom service provider's own huge user base. On a different service provider, Wynk Music will allow you to stream only 100 songs per month, while costing ₹99 per month for downloading. Airtel users on the other hand can download for ₹29 per month and listen to unlimited free songs.

It's a major bummer, since Wynk's collection of both Indian and western is actually quite good, but if you're an avid music listener, you'll probably blast through 100 tracks in a day or two. Remember though, that Wynk is completely ad free, so the limits are somewhat more justified than

What you need to know about streaming services

- Streaming music services pay artists on a 'per stream' basis, meaning, each time you play a song by a particular artist, they're paid based on the duration you played for. Especially in India, most of the rights are held by record labels, meaning a streaming service pays the label or aggregator, which then pays the artist. In many cases, there is a payment pool that is created, and payouts are based on the percentage of share a record label has in that pool.
- All of these streaming services, except Apple Music and Wynk, are ad supported, which means that unless you're subscribing to them, their means of revenues are through the ads that play between songs. In a country like India, where Internet connections are unstable, these ads inhibit the streaming experience to an extent, but it isn't crippling.
- Streaming music does incur data charges, but the data usage also isn't as significant as many think. Having used streaming services as our main source of music for almost a month, with over an hour of streaming almost every day, at 192 kbps or above, we have noted that about 1.5 GB of data is used per month. While this is a fairly large number for many, if you're on Wi-Fi for most of your day, you can easily stream music.
- Many or most streaming services don't allow songs to be saved on the SD card. The reason for this is that internal storage is faster, but more importantly, because the apps are not given permission to access the SD card. Amongst the ones mentioned here, Rdio allows saving to SD card, but it can be a difficult endeavour.

Saavn's 3GB after paying ₹110. Wynk's app may not be the best looking amongst all of these, but it's still simple enough. Airtel has put almost everything you need on the home screen itself, to ensure that you start listening the minute you enter the app. The Indian collection gives Gaana and Saavn a run for their money, while the western collection isn't up there with Rdio and the gang.

Hungama

If you had used Hungama last year, you would know how serious the company is about streaming music. The app recently received a total UI overhaul, looking much better than before. It is still not at par with any of the other apps on this list though. The app still seems sloppy and just doesn't look inviting compared to its competitors. It got stuck at loading a few times and crashed unexpectedly too. Hungama also needs to work on its web app and give it a good UI overhaul as well.

In addition, Hungama's focus is on Indian music, with a seriously limited collection of international tracks. If you listen to a lot of western music, then you should definitely stay away from this one.

Hungama's ₹110 per month subscription is competitively priced. There are also



Wynk

daily operator billing plans at starting at ₹5, while weekly billing can be opted for at ₹30 as well. Hungama also gives a-la-carte options for downloading. The app's main strength though is in the fact that it is available in multiple languages, apart from Hindi and English.

And the best service is?

None of these streaming apps, including Apple Music, are perfect right now. Still, considering the fact that Apple Music isn't on Android, we'd recommend **Rdio** to users who listen to a lot of international music and want a really good looking, simple and easy to use app. However, if you're looking for more Indian music, with a decent collection of western tracks, Gaana seems to be the right choice.